

The Indian Perspective

As far as decades go with regard to their importance in Indian history, the 90s were almost at par with the 40s... Gaining freedom from the bureaucratic red tape under the License Raj was almost as epochal as gaining freedom from the British.

The then Finance Minister and present Prime Minister, Dr Manmohan Singh, who was instrumental in the process, was probably left with little choice given the fact that India was at the brink of bankruptcy after all the years of hermetic socialism.

The 90s also saw the freedom from state-controlled broadcast media, and for the first time, ordinary Indians had a clutch of channels to choose from. No longer was Prannoy Roy's *The World this Week* the most popular way to get to know what was happening around the world. And finally, Indians, too, were able to undertake journeys into cyberspace for the first time.

From an IT perspective, two major influences brought the PC closer to the ordinary Indian. First, the increased interaction and competition with foreign entities, post-liberalisation, brought home to Indians the need for automation to survive in the market. This resulted in many businesses using PCs for the first time.

Liberalisation also led to increased job and business opportunities, resulting in unprecedented pay packets and increased spending power—which also resulted in more PCs being installed in homes. PCs were no longer seen as an extravagance, rather as a critical investment.

The decade also saw the rise of the tech firms like TCS and Infosys, thanks to the over-hyped Y2K phenomenon, which played a not-so-insignificant role in bringing Indian software coding prowess to the global limelight.